

Q3 2026 · MARKET INSIGHTS & TRENDS

A hard look at the financial wellbeing space

More employers offer financial wellness programs than at any point on record. Employer confidence that those programs work has fallen thirty points in two years. The gap between them is what happens when everyone gets paid before anyone knows whether it worked.

Eight findings

One of them sits underneath the other seven. In this category everybody is paid before anyone knows whether it worked, and that single arrangement explains most of what the data shows. **Section One** starts there.

70%

EMPLOYERS OFFERING

Employer adoption is at a record high. Seven in ten large employers offered some financial wellness initiative in 2025, up from 59 percent a year earlier. This figure counts what employers offer. It says nothing about whether an employee used it.

70–85%

OF PEPM SPEND

Most program spend produces nothing. At industry-average engagement, the majority of per-employee-per-month fees attach to employees who never engage — and they are **invoiced before anyone knows which employees those will be.**

43%

SAY IT WORKS

Confidence is collapsing. The share of employers reporting their programs make a large impact fell to 43 percent, from 73 percent in 2023. A thirty-point drop in two years.

2.1×

NET WORTH, ADVISED

Advised households do markedly better. Advised households hold an average net worth of \$800,000 against \$388,000 for non-advised peers, in a sample matched on age, income band and other demographics.

40%

WANT A PERSON, NOT A PORTAL

Employees ask for one-on-one advice. Forty percent rank it as the single most helpful resource for reducing financial worry, ahead of every digital tool in the category.

3×

PLAN COST VS. SAVINGS

The deliverable costs more than the buffer. A flat-fee financial plan averages about \$2,900. Thirty percent of employees hold less than \$1,000 in emergency savings.

54→70%

EMPLOYERS OFFERING,
2023 TO 2025

The failure is not underinvestment. More employers bought in each year, and confidence fell thirty points over the same two years. That points to a ceiling in how the model is funded rather than how it is built.

51%

RE-BIDDING VENDORS

The market is moving. Half of large employers are changing or re-bidding their health and wellbeing vendors. Cutting a benefit outright is rarely an acceptable answer.

01

The model

Every party is paid *before the product proves itself*. *The model is broken*.

02

What "offering financial wellness" counts

Clients already "offer" it. Worldwide, *only 11 percent of employees* say they get financial education from it.

03

Spending up, confidence down

Clients are renewing programs that *only 43 percent of buyers* say work.

04

Knows versus has

Employees don't lack knowledge. They *lack cash margin*.

05

A person, not a portal

Employees rank *one-on-one advice* ahead of every tool. Advised households hold *twice the net worth*.

06

The consolidation squeeze

Half your clients plan to re-bid. *Cutting it is the worst answer*.

07

Why product cannot fix it

Competitive solutions won't fix it. The ceiling is how it is funded.

08

An evaluation framework

Ten questions for your next RFP that *feature comparison will not surface*.

—

About the sponsor

A new model that rewards impact. And it's free to launch.

It is not the product. It is the **model**. Everyone in this category is paid for **access** to an employee, up front, before anyone knows whether a single employee is better off.

Four parties transact around an employee's financial health. Two are paid in full at placement, one pays in full regardless, and the employee is left where they started. Every other finding in this report runs downstream of that one arrangement, which is why it comes first.

Set the product aside and look only at who invoices whom. A typical arrangement has four parties: the platform vendor that licenses the software, the referring party who places and services it, the employer that buys it, and the employee whose finances are the point of the exercise.

Platform vendor Paid per eligible employee, monthly	→	Paid in full Revenue is unaffected by engagement
Referring party Compensated for placing and servicing the benefit	→	Paid at placement Compensation is fixed when the contract is signed, not by what the benefit produces afterward
Employer Pays PEPM plus implementation and platform fees	→	Pays in full, receives nothing Cost is fixed, outcome is not
Employee Receives tools free; a fiduciary-built plan costs retail	→	Pays, or goes without The party with the most at stake and the least protection

Read down the right-hand column. The parties who sell and place the benefit are made whole before any outcome exists, the employer pays whether or not one arrives, and the one party whose finances are the subject of the exercise gets tools instead of a plan built for them by a fiduciary. None of this is a criticism of the people involved: referring parties and vendors are behaving rationally inside a structure none of them designed. The structure is the problem.

The part that does the damage is the timing

The table above shows who is paid. The sharper problem is *when*. Per-employee-per-month fees are invoiced from the first month of the contract, calculated on everyone eligible, and collected before a single employee has opened the product. The vendor's revenue for the year is effectively settled at signature. The employer's return, if there is one, arrives much later or not at all. Nothing in the structure requires the two events to ever meet, which is why a vendor can post a strong year in the same period its buyers' confidence falls thirty points.

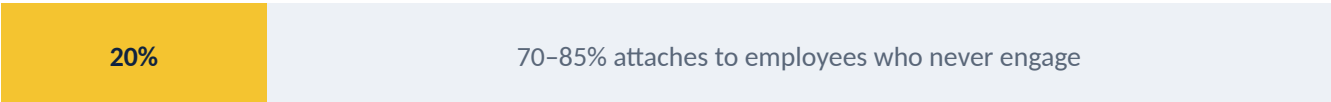
The inverse structure exists. It is uncommon in the benefits market and more familiar from advisory referral arrangements: the provider funds the substantive deliverable at its own expense, hands it over, and is compensated only afterward, and only if the employee acts on it. Every employee who takes the deliverable and stops there is a real loss carried by the provider rather than by the employer. The two models can ship identical software. They cannot behave identically, because only one of them has anything to lose.

PAID FOR ACCESS	PAID FOR OUTCOME
Month one Fees begin at contract start, per eligible employee, whether or not anyone engages. Revenue is complete before proof exists. The employer carries the entire risk that nothing changes, and absorbs it as a fixed line item.	After the fact The provider funds delivery upfront and is compensated only once an employee has acted on it. The provider carries the loss on everyone who does not. The employer carries no cost and therefore no risk.

Payment precedes proof. Employers have rarely had the option of buying financial wellness any other way: pay up front, for unknown results, and absorb it if nothing moves.

Where per-employee-per-month spend lands

Illustration at engagement of 15 to 30 percent. Price and engagement are assumptions chosen for scale, not published benchmarks



At \$10 PEPM across 10,000 employees:

\$840,000 to \$1.02M

of \$1.2M annual spend buys no measurable change.

One caution about reading that chart. It is not an argument for raising engagement. Section Four sets out why the engaged minority does not fare much better: what they engage *with* is information, which does not move the condition data. A platform at 100 percent engagement would produce a fully informed workforce with the same bank balances. The waste is not that too few employees open the product. It is that opening it was never going to be the thing that helped.

The point-solution model also never built a path to an advisor. Advisory practices serve the households that reach them, and the tools the category sells were not designed to bring a rank-and-file employee with \$9,000 and a genuine question to one. That employee is not underserved by anyone's intent. There was simply nothing in the model that took them there.

It is worth being precise about what the alternative would require, because it is more demanding than outcome-based pricing usually implies. Not a rebate if engagement misses a threshold, and not a fee at risk. It would mean that no party in the chain — not the broker, not the platform, not the advisor — is compensated at all until an individual employee has done the thing most likely to change their finances: had a real, personalized plan built, and then chosen to keep working on it with the person who built it. Payment would attach to that decision and to nothing else.

THE TAKEAWAY Every party but the employee is made whole at signature.

The rest of this report is an examination of why the incumbent structure cannot get there, and what the evidence says about the cost of it not getting there.

TWO

What "offering financial wellness" actually counts

The 70 percent figure counts employers who offer something, in a category with no fixed definition of what that something is. Understanding what sits inside it explains much of the confidence gap.

Financial wellness is an umbrella term. In practice it includes education workshops, budgeting and aggregation tools, emergency savings vehicles, student loan assistance, retirement match features, coaching, and earned wage access. An employer offering a single lunch-and-learn and an employer running a full advisory benefit both answer yes to the same survey question.

The composition skews heavily toward the low-cost end. Globally, only **11 percent of employees say they receive financial education from their employer**, while 37 percent expect it. Student loan repayment assistance, one of the more substantive offerings, reached 14 percent of surveyed organizations in 2024, up from 4 percent in 2019. Pension-linked emergency savings accounts under SECURE 2.0 carry a balance cap of \$2,600 for 2026 (IRS Notice 2025-67).

What sits inside the 70 percent

Share of employers. The second bar is a belief measure, not a component — it is shown here for scale against what is actually offered

Some financial wellness initiative



Believe it makes a large impact



Offer student loan assistance



Employees receiving financial education from employer (global)



Sources: EBRI Financial Wellbeing Employer Survey 2025 (n=406), via CNBC; IFEBP, Education Benefits: 2024 Survey Report (n=365); Aon, A Comprehensive Approach to Financial Wellbeing, March 2025 (global employee data). Categories drawn from different surveys and are indicative rather than directly comparable.

Who is counting whom

Vendors in the category compete substantially on reach rather than on outcomes. Recordkeeper platforms publish engagement across participant bases in the tens of millions. Venture-backed platforms cite planner network size, country coverage, and app-store rankings. One prominent employee platform advertises planner coverage in more than 75 countries and has raised tens of millions in venture funding.

None of these are outcome measures. They describe distribution. In a category where 43 percent of buyers say the product works, distribution figures are the wrong scoreboard.

THE TAKEAWAY Seventy percent offer something. Much of it sits at the low-cost end, and the category keeps score on reach because reach is what its revenue rewards.

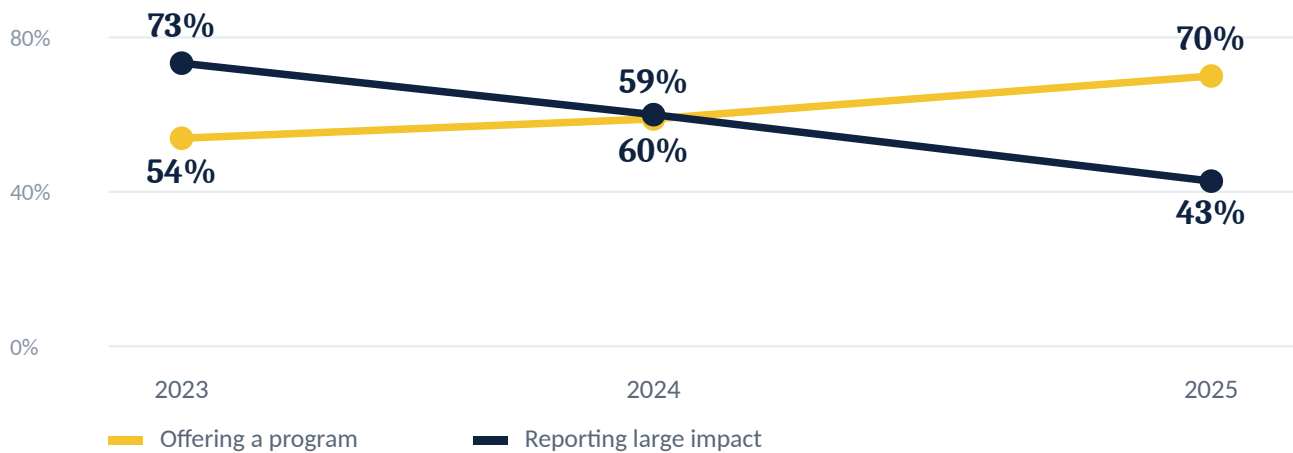
THREE

Spending up, confidence down

The clearest signal in the 2026 research is a divergence between how many employers offer financial wellness and how many believe it is working.

Employers offering a program vs. employers reporting a large impact

2023 to 2025



Source: EBRI Financial Wellbeing Employer Survey, 2023 to 2025 waves (n=252, 262 and 406 benefits decision makers at companies with 500 or more employees that offer or are interested in financial wellness programs), as reported by CNBC, January 16, 2026, and EBRI's December 2025 Financial Wellbeing Symposium materials.

Confidence fell thirty points over two years while the share offering a program rose sixteen. The finding comes from a research institute funded by a broad consortium rather than a single vendor, which distinguishes it from most return-on-investment claims in the category.

The category is being bought more widely than at any point in its history and believed in less.

The measurement problem underneath

Published engagement rates are frequently built on definitions that will not survive a direct question. One major recordkeeper's published methodology counts a participant as engaged after "at least three interactions on the participant website, mobile apps, or call center in a 12-month period." Three app opens in a year qualifies. Nothing in the definition requires a decision, a contribution change, or a conversation.

THE TAKEAWAY

Buyers stopped believing the category faster than any product cycle could explain, and the numbers vendors publish to reassure them count a few logins as engagement.

FOUR

The category has built tools that change what an employee **knows**. Almost nothing changes what an employee **has**.

This is the single largest explanation for the confidence gap, and it is a design choice rather than an execution failure.

The condition data does not describe a population that is short on motivation or information. Forty-eight percent of employees say they are highly motivated to learn budgeting, investing, credit, and debt management, and 59 percent are financially stressed anyway. It describes a population operating without cash margin.

WHAT THE CATEGORY BUILT

Account aggregation dashboards

Budgeting and spend categorization

Content libraries and articles

AI assistants and chatbots

Webinars and lunch-and-learns

Net worth trackers

Goal-setting modules

Changes what an employee knows.

WHAT THE CONDITION REQUIRES

Cash in an emergency account

Debt principal reduced

Employer match captured

A plan they did not pay for

A decision made at the right moment

Changes what an employee has.

Every item in the left column scales at near-zero marginal cost. Nothing in the right column does. Where a vendor's revenue is a function of covered lives, the left column is the rational product. The economics selected the intervention.

The employee condition it is aimed at

FINDING	SHARE OF EMPLOYEES
Currently financially stressed	59%
Have less than \$5,000 in emergency savings	53%
Have less than \$1,000	30%
Use credit cards for necessities they cannot otherwise afford	44%
Have used payday loans or advances	39%
Think it likely they will need to tap retirement funds	52%
Gen X confident they can retire when they want to	38%

Source: PwC 2026 Employee Financial Wellness Survey, nearly 3,500 US employees, fielded January 2026.

FIVE

Employees are asking for a person, not a portal.

40%

of employees rank one-on-one advice as the single most helpful resource for reducing financial worry, ahead of every digital tool in the category.

Source: CAPTRUST, Financial Wellness Survey Report 2026, n=4,307 employees at 795 employers that offer CAPTRUST at Work, fielded May 2025. The sample is CAPTRUST's client base, so read it as a signal of preference rather than a market-wide measure.

Budgeting apps, webinars, calculators and coaching all trail a conversation with a qualified person. Employees know what they want. Interest is not the binding constraint. Price is.

The price in question is roughly \$2,900 for a flat-fee financial plan, against the under \$1,000 that thirty percent of employees hold in emergency savings. An employee weighing whether to pay down debt or raise a retirement contribution does not spend three times their cash reserve to resolve the question. A complete plan is the thing most likely to help, and for most employees it is priced out of reach.

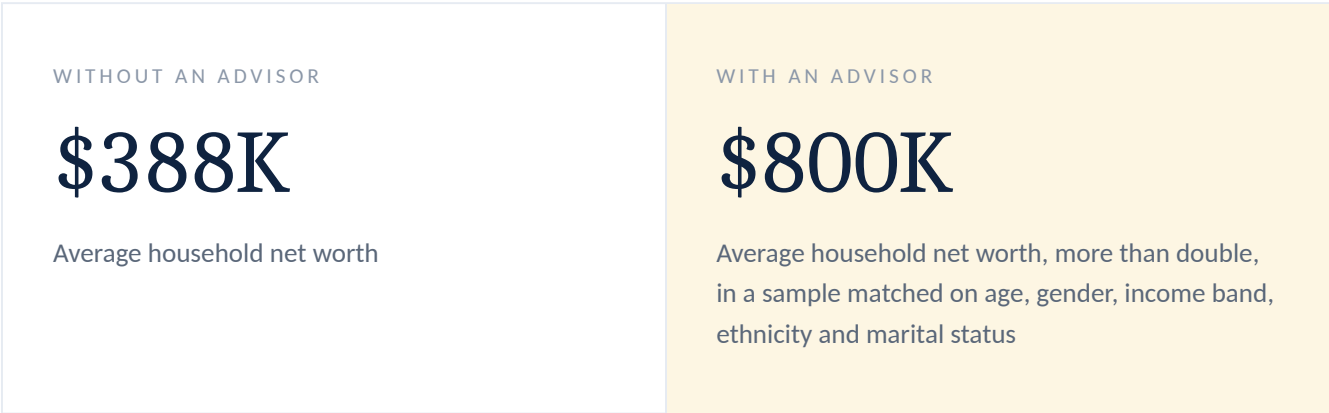
Sources: Investnet MoneyGuide, 2026 State of Financial Planning Fees, n=491 advisors, fielded Q1 2026 (average flat planning fee); PwC 2026 Employee Financial Wellness Survey for emergency savings.

That is a claim about which constraint binds first, not a claim that price is the only one. Removing cost does not produce universal uptake: awareness, timing, and trust still govern whether a given employee acts, and any model that offers a complete plan at no cost should be expected to reach a large minority of a workforce rather than all of it. The useful comparison is against the minority of a workforce that engages with the tools employers buy today, and against the share of those who end up with a plan, which is close to none.

Every incumbent model in this category is solving a problem employees do not have, and leaving the one they do have priced out of reach.

And advised households do better, at every income level

Until recently, the case for advice rested largely on portfolio return estimates. The TIAA Institute's May 2026 study, based on a nationwide survey of 1,864 adults, measures behavior and wealth directly.



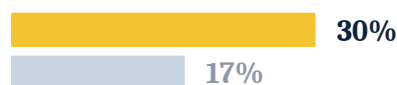
Financial behaviors, advised vs. non-advised households

Percentage of households

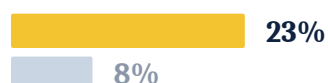
Save consistently



Contribute regularly to a retirement account



Invest in mutual funds



— Advised — Non-advised

Source: TIAA Institute, "The Value of Financial Advice," May 2026, n=1,864 adults aged 18 to 79, fielded October 2025. The study models an equivalent value of 140 to 240 basis points a year for three illustrative households, before fees, and finds a 14 to 19 percentage point advantage in financial confidence. **Read with the same caution this report asks of any figure:** these are averages rather than medians (the medians are \$175,000 and \$62,500), so the top of the distribution pulls them upward, and the study is observational. It matches the two groups on age, gender, income band, ethnicity and marital status but cannot fully separate the effect of advice from the disposition of people who seek it out. The behavioural gaps below are the more robust finding; the net worth multiple is the more quotable one.

The effect is not confined to wealthy households. Among those earning under \$50,000 annually, 85 percent of advised individuals save or invest, against 65 percent of non-advised. The study's authors note the impact holds at every level of wealth.

THE IMPLICATION

Two findings sit side by side in the 2026 research: advice produces materially better outcomes at every income level, and employees rank one-on-one advice ahead of every digital tool. The category has spent a decade building everything except that.

SIX

The consolidation squeeze, and why cutting is the worst answer

Employers are under real pressure to reduce benefits spend. They are also acutely aware that removing a benefit is among the most damaging signals an employer can send.

Benefits consultants reporting point-solution fatigue among clients (digital health, 2024)	84%
Of those, clients considering consolidating under one navigation solution	63%
Large employers changing or re-bidding health and wellbeing vendors (2026 survey)	51%

Sources: MedCity News and Quantum Health, 2024 Healthcare Benefit Consultant Sentiment Index (100+ benefits consultants); Business Group on Health, 2026 Employer Health Care Strategy Survey (n=121 large employers).

The instinct reading those numbers is that targeted solutions are falling out of favor. That is not what the data says. The operative filter is narrower: a benefit is cut when it carries a visible line item and cannot demonstrate who used it or what changed.

This creates a genuine bind. Benefits are among the most visible signals of how an employer regards its workforce, and taking one away is read as a statement regardless of the financial logic behind it. An HR leader who removes financial wellness in a year when 59 percent of employees report financial stress is making an announcement they did not intend to make.

Removing a benefit is never a neutral act. The pressure to consolidate and the cost of visibly retreating are pushing employers toward the same place: alternative models that carry no line item.

Two structural answers exist. The first is a benefit with no employer cost, which cannot be cut on price and is therefore evaluated on merit alone. The second is a model that moves an employee's actual position — cash, debt, a plan they own — rather than their level of information, addressing the gap identified in **Section Four**. Models combining both are the natural destination of the current pressure.

THE TAKEAWAY

The squeeze and the reputational cost of retreating push toward the same destination: a benefit that carries no line item at all, and therefore cannot be cut on price.

The category has not failed for lack of **product investment**. It has iterated hard, and the outcome data went the wrong way.

Which means the constraint sits below the product, in how the model is funded.

Between 2023 and 2025 the category shipped its most significant product cycle to date. Platforms added AI assistants, equity compensation modeling, estate planning, tax filing, and in at least one case an SEC-regulated AI advisor. Planner networks expanded across dozens of countries. Venture funding continued.

Across the same three years, the share of employers reporting a large impact fell from 73 percent to 43 percent.

A thirty-point decline in buyer confidence during the category's strongest product cycle is not an execution problem. It is a design ceiling.

Three constraints that no feature release reaches

Revenue is per eligible employee

The vendor is paid the same whether one employee engages or all of them do



Rewards breadth, not depth

Only interventions that scale at near-zero marginal cost are viable, which excludes anything that puts money in an employee's hands

A fiduciary-built plan for everyone is not in the model

Point solutions offer planning tools, and sometimes a plan for those who pay for one. A personalized plan from a fiduciary, for every employee, is not part of the model, and at retail it costs about three times what thirty percent of employees hold in savings



The proven intervention is unreachable

The one intervention associated with doubled net worth is structurally unavailable to the employees who most need it

The benefit is an employer line item

Every improvement in depth raises cost per employee



Improvement runs against the market

Spending more per head runs against a market in which half of large employers are re-bidding their wellbeing vendors

Read together, these describe a closed loop. The fix for the outcome problem is depth: fewer employees served more substantively, with real advice and direct financial support. The fix for the cost problem is the reverse. A vendor operating on per-eligible-employee revenue cannot deliver the first without violating the second, because the money to fund depth would have to come from the employer, at the precise moment employers are removing exactly those line items.

THE BIND, STATED PLAINLY

Improving outcomes within the current model requires spending more per employee. The market is moving in the opposite direction. Both cannot be satisfied by a better product, because they are not product problems.

Where innovation has to come from

If the ceiling is set by the funding structure, then the variable that has to change is who pays, when they pay, and what triggers payment. That is a narrow design space, and it produces a short list of requirements any next-generation model has to satisfy at once.

WHAT A DURABLE MODEL HAS TO DO SIMULTANEOUSLY

Carry no employer line item, so it cannot be cut on price in a consolidation cycle

Deliver the intervention with proven outcomes, which is advice, not information

Reach every employee, not only the high earners the space usually targets

Change what the employee has, not only what they know

Produce something the employee keeps, independent of employment

Pay every party only when an individual employee has taken a substantive step, not when a population becomes eligible

In our reading, no incumbent model in this report satisfies more than two of these at once.

That last requirement is the one that resolves the others. Where compensation across all parties is contingent on an employee finding real value rather than on eligibility, the incentive to maximize covered lives at minimum cost per life disappears, and with it the pressure that produced a decade of dashboards.

Models of this shape are new and largely unproven at scale. The evidence in this report establishes that the incumbent structure has reached its ceiling. It does not establish that any particular alternative clears it. That is a question for diligence, and **the framework in the following section** is built to ask it.

EIGHT

An evaluation framework

Product features across the category have largely converged. These questions surface structural differences that feature comparison does not.

1 What is the vendor's revenue in a year when engagement is low?

Compensation structure predicts most other design choices. If the answer is "the same as any other year," every subsequent answer follows from it.

2 When is the vendor paid, relative to when the employee benefits?

Ask for the invoicing schedule, not the pricing page. If fees are collected before any outcome could be observed, the vendor has no exposure to the outcome, and the employer holds all of it.

3 Does the benefit change what employees know, or what they have?

The distinction separates most of the category from the small part of it that moves condition data.

4 What share of interactions does the platform initiate, and around which events?

Financial decisions are event-driven. Open enrollment is one such event and a natural activation moment, but a model that only shows up then misses job changes, births, vests, and moves.

5 What does a new employee see before typing anything?

Search bars and content libraries presuppose a formed question. Those with most to gain are least likely to have one.

6 What employer-side data does the platform ingest?

Account aggregation misses benefits elections, plan design, and payroll deductions.

7 What does the employee retain at termination?

Job change is a high-stakes financial event and a common moment of retirement plan leakage.

8 Where does the first dollar of employee cost appear?

Free to start is not the same as free. Establish whether the plan itself sits behind the paywall, or whether the plan is complete and free and only an ongoing relationship is optional and paid. The first is a sample. The second is a benefit.

9 What happens to this benefit if the client reduces benefits spend by 15 percent?

Cost structure determines which benefits are evaluated on merit and which are cut on price.

10 Does the benefit give the employer anything to reinvest, and how is that verified?

Nearly every benefit in this category is a net consumer of budget, which is why it is the first thing examined in a consolidation cycle. The harder question is whether a benefit can also return value the employer can redirect — against premium costs, into other benefits, or into extending this one further — so that a single line of spend compounds rather than depletes. Where a vendor claims this, establish what the figure is a share of and who calculates it.

ON RETURN-ON-INVESTMENT CLAIMS

The most frequently cited ROI figures in this category are vendor-produced, rarely replicated independently, and often lack a disclosed control group. The denominator, control group, and funding source are worth establishing before any figure is used. This applies equally to the sponsor of this report.

ABOUT THE SPONSOR

AssetAlign

AssetAlign is a financial wellness benefit built around a different funding structure than the models described in this report.

Every employee is offered a complete, personalized financial plan, prepared for them by an independent fiduciary advisor, at no cost to the employee and no cost to the employer. Every employee who takes it up receives one. The plan is a full deliverable rather than a preview, and the employee retains it independently of continued employment.

The division of labour matters to how the rest of this section reads. The advice is given by the independent advisors who prepare the plans and who hold the client relationship afterward. AssetAlign arranges the benefit and funds the plans; it is not the party giving the advice.

Employees who choose to continue working with the independent advisor who prepared their plan pay that advisor's standard, disclosed fees. A defined share of those fees funds distributions back to the employee population, an employer flex fund that can be applied against premium costs or other benefits spend, and, where the placing broker elects it, the broker's compensation. Nothing is charged to the employer or the employee before that point.

The consequence is that AssetAlign carries the cost of the plans upfront. Every plan delivered to an employee who takes it and goes no further is a loss absorbed by AssetAlign, not billed to the employer. The model is compensated only where an employee has decided, on their own, to keep working on their finances. That is the inversion described in **Section One**: proof precedes payment rather than following it.

Neither the employer nor the employee pays anyone — not the broker, not the platform, not the advisor, not AssetAlign — until an employee has a real, personalized plan and has chosen to keep working on it with the advisor who built it.

The trigger is deliberately the healthiest action that can actually be observed. Not a login, not a module completed, not a webinar attended, and not an engagement rate. A plan built for that specific employee, and that employee's own decision to keep going with the person who built it. That decision is observable, it is made by the employee rather than reported by the vendor, and it is the point at which every party in the chain becomes payable — the broker included — and not one moment earlier.

It is worth stating how strict that test is against the rest of the category. Every incumbent model in this report is compensated for giving an employee access to help. Access is what 70 percent of employers already offer and what 43 percent still believe in. This model is compensated for something further down the line: a named employee who has had a plan built around their actual circumstances and has decided to keep building on it. That is the difference between an employee who has been offered a better financial position and an employee who has started taking one. Nobody here is paid for the offer.

A generous engagement definition inflates a vendor's numbers at no cost to the vendor. **Section Three** of this report documents a recordkeeper counting three website or app interactions in a year as engagement. The reason the trigger here is a plan plus a decision to continue is that it is the one event AssetAlign cannot loosen in its own favour: a looser definition would not pay anyone more, because payment depends on an employee choosing to keep going, not on AssetAlign reporting that they engaged. This is the answer to the first two questions of **the framework in Section Eight**, and employers should hold AssetAlign to them as strictly as they hold anyone else.

One further distinction sits on the broker side. Compensation there is elective rather than automatic: a broker who places AssetAlign decides whether to be compensated at all, and some choose not to be. What the employee receives and what the employer pays are unaffected either way. A broker can therefore put this in front of a client without having taken a position on their own compensation first, which is not something the per-employee-per-month model permits.

Because the model reaches employees at transitional moments, including open enrollment, it also identifies when existing retirement and advisory services become relevant, making it additive to a firm's existing financial services rather than competitive with them.

Two limits, stated plainly

The report asks this of every model in it, so it should answer for itself. First, the trigger is a strong indicator rather than a measurement. A decision to keep working with an advisor says an employee found real value; it does not track their net worth a decade out, and no compensation structure available today can wait that long. What it does is move the payment point from eligibility, which tells you nothing, to a deliberate act by a named individual, which tells you a great deal.

Second, the ongoing relationship is an ordinary advisory relationship, with the advisor's standard disclosed fees. The plan is different. It is complete and free to every employee regardless of balance, and that is the part that reaches the rank and file the rest of the category never gets to. The claim is that this model removes the price barrier at the plan; what happens after that is between the employee and the advisor they chose.

What this looks like at a thousand employees

The rates below are drawn from AssetAlign placements to date rather than modelled. They are shown at a round headcount because the structure is hard to picture in the abstract, and because the only figure an employer actually needs to check is the first one.

1,000 eligible employees

Introduced at open enrollment, and again at job changes, births, vests and moves



Employer cost: none

No PEPM, no platform fee, no implementation fee

400 complete a financial plan

A completion rate, not an engagement rate: 40 percent finished a plan, observed across placements to date

400 plans delivered

Complete and personalized, retained by the employee regardless of employment

280 continue with their advisor

Seven in ten of those who completed a plan, observed across placements to date

The model is funded

Advisor fees are disclosed and paid by the employee; a defined share funds employee distributions and the employer flex fund

120 keep the plan and stop there

By the standard set in Section Four this is not a failure: 120 employees now hold a plan they did not pay for

AssetAlign absorbs the cost

The employee keeps the plan. No party bills anyone for it

Basis: plan completion and continuation observed across AssetAlign placements to date. Rates vary materially by employer, workforce composition, and how the benefit is communicated. Past results are not a projection or a guarantee of future results.

ON THE FLEX FUND FIGURE

We do not quote a flex fund number for a specific employer without a census. Any illustrative estimator we provide shows its assumptions alongside the number. The distribution to employees and the amount available to the employer are a function of what the continuing employees' advisory fees actually are, which depends on their assets, the complexity of their situations, and the fee schedule they agree to. Any figure quoted to an employer without a census behind it would be marketing rather than arithmetic. AssetAlign will model both against your census, with the assumptions written down, before anything is signed.

Methodology. This report analyses published third-party research. No proprietary or client data was used outside the sponsor section, whose completion and continuation rates are AssetAlign's own. Incumbent platforms are described by model type. Where a specific published figure is used, its source is named here.

Employee condition and engagement. PwC, 2026 Employee Financial Wellness Survey (nearly 3,500 US employees, fielded January 2026). CAPTRUST, Financial Wellness Survey Report 2026 (n=4,307 employees at 795 employers offering CAPTRUST at Work, fielded May 2025). Aon, A Comprehensive Approach to Financial Wellbeing, March 2025 (global employee data on financial education).

Value of advice. TIAA Institute, The value of financial advice, May 2026 (n=1,864 US adults aged 18 to 79, fielded October 2025). Net worth figures are group means from a sample matched on age, gender, income band, ethnicity and marital status; the return-equivalent estimate is modelled for illustrative households, before fees.

Employer purchasing and confidence. EBRI Financial Wellbeing Employer Survey, 2023 to 2025 waves (n=252, 262 and 406 benefits decision makers at companies with 500 or more employees that offer or are interested in financial wellness programs), as reported by CNBC, January 16, 2026, and EBRI's December 2025 Financial Wellbeing Symposium materials. EBRI's full issue briefs are available to EBRI members.

Market structure. Business Group on Health, 2026 Employer Health Care Strategy Survey (n=121 large employers, fielded June to July 2025). MedCity News and Quantum Health, 2024 Healthcare Benefit Consultant Sentiment Index (100+ benefits consultants, spring 2024; figures concern digital health point solutions). IFEBP, Education Benefits: 2024 Survey Report (n=365 US organizations). Empower, Empowering America's Financial Journey 2025, methodology note (engagement definition). IRS Notice 2025-67 (2026 pension-linked emergency savings account limit).

Pricing. Envestnet MoneyGuide, 2026 State of Financial Planning Fees (n=491 advisors, fielded Q1 2026). The per-employee-per-month illustration in Section Three uses assumed price and engagement values chosen for scale, not published benchmarks.

A note on retention figures. Retention statistics widely quoted in this category (financially stressed employees twice as likely to be looking for a new job, 36 percent versus 18 percent) originate in PwC's 2023 survey of 3,638 full-time employees, not the 2026 wave, and PwC no longer hosts the 2023 report. A number of 2026 sources misattribute them. They remain the best available data on the subject, but the survey year should be cited.

A note on the sponsor section. The thousand-employee walkthrough applies plan completion and continuation rates observed across AssetAlign placements to a round headcount, chosen for legibility rather than to describe a typical client. Rates vary by employer, and past results are not a projection. Figures modelled for a specific employer are produced from that employer's census with the assumptions written down.

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Figures are attributed to the published sources listed in the methodology.

Past results are not a projection or a guarantee of future results.